

Campaign 1

Belgium concert + masterclass announcement

results report

5,644

active subscribers reached

100%

audience saturation

5

subject lines tested

2

A/B experiments

4

paid orders attributed

50%

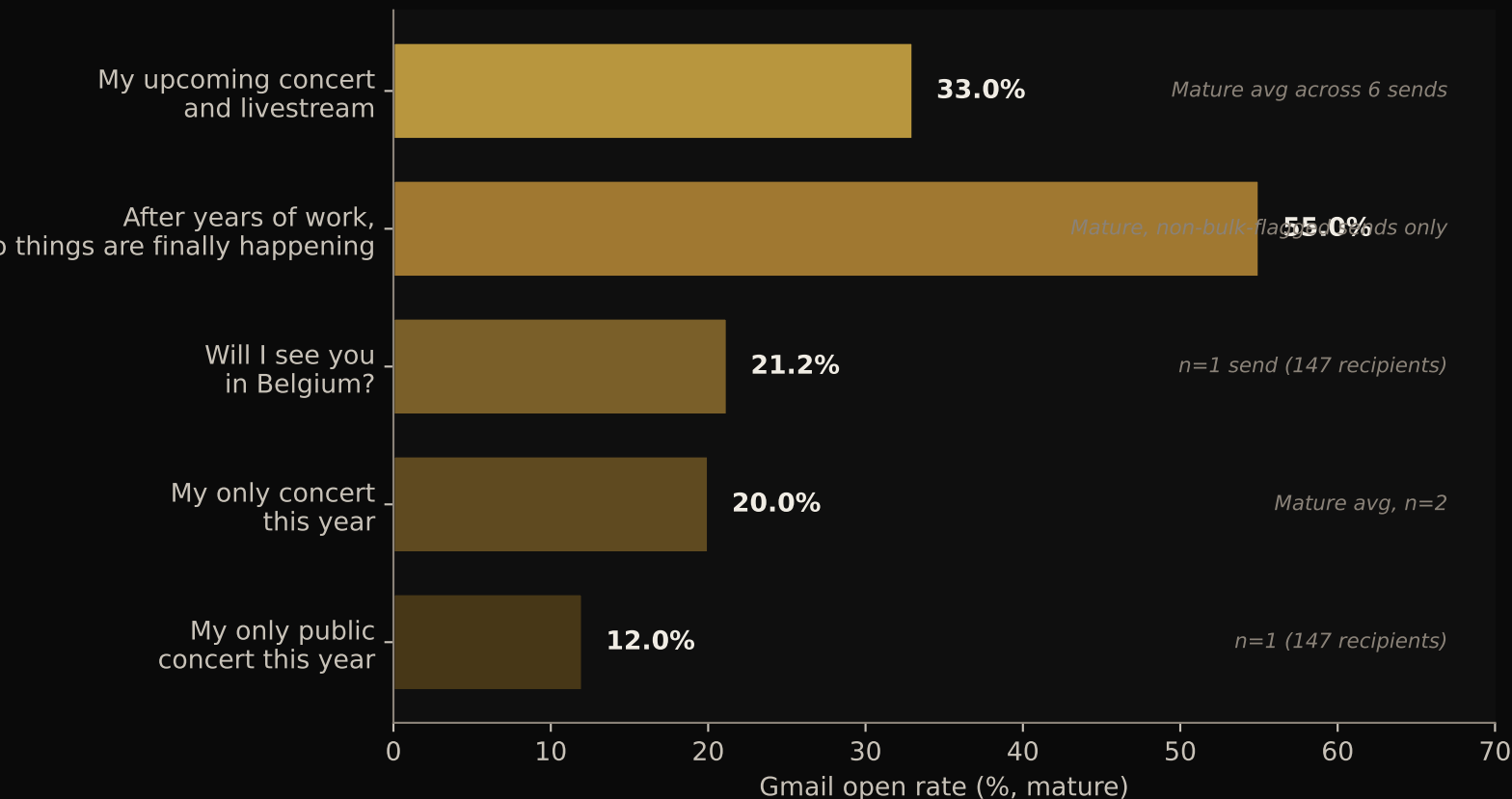
of orders from email funnel

2026-05-01 through 2026-05-21

Variant A + Variant B parent templates, 12 audited sends, ~16,500 emails delivered

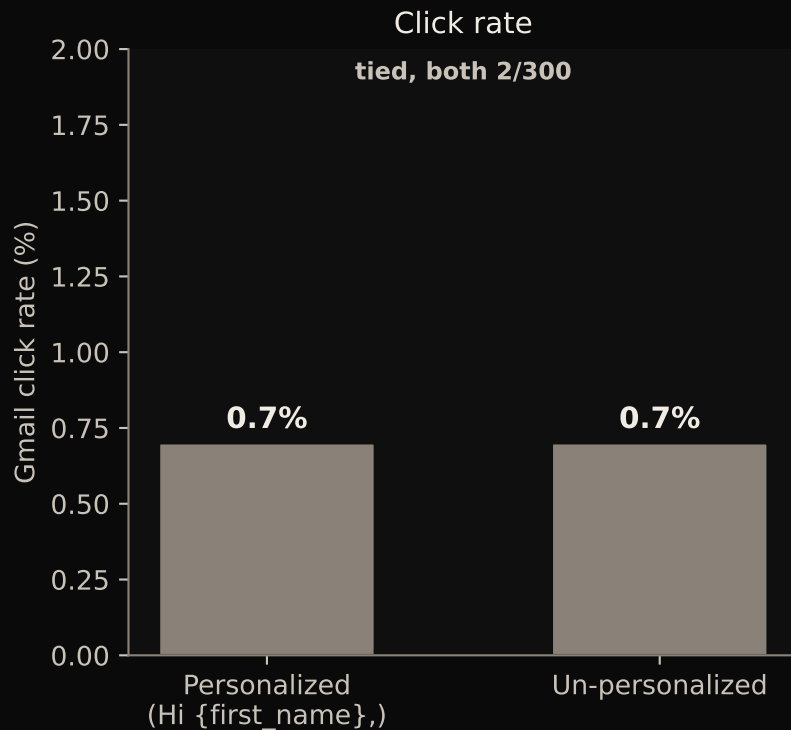
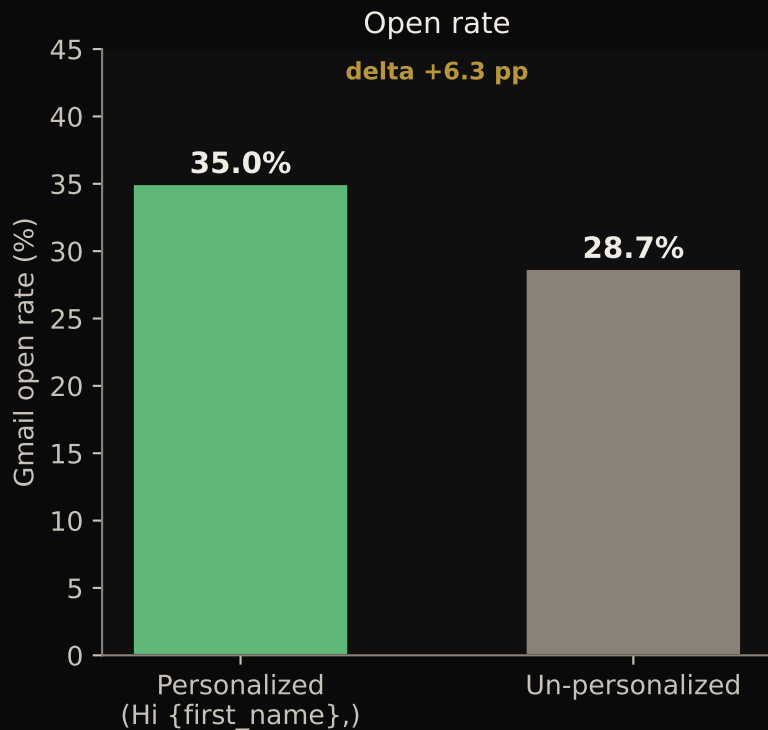
Generated from docs/CAMPAIGN-1-RESULTS.md

Subject line performance, Gmail-only mature open rates



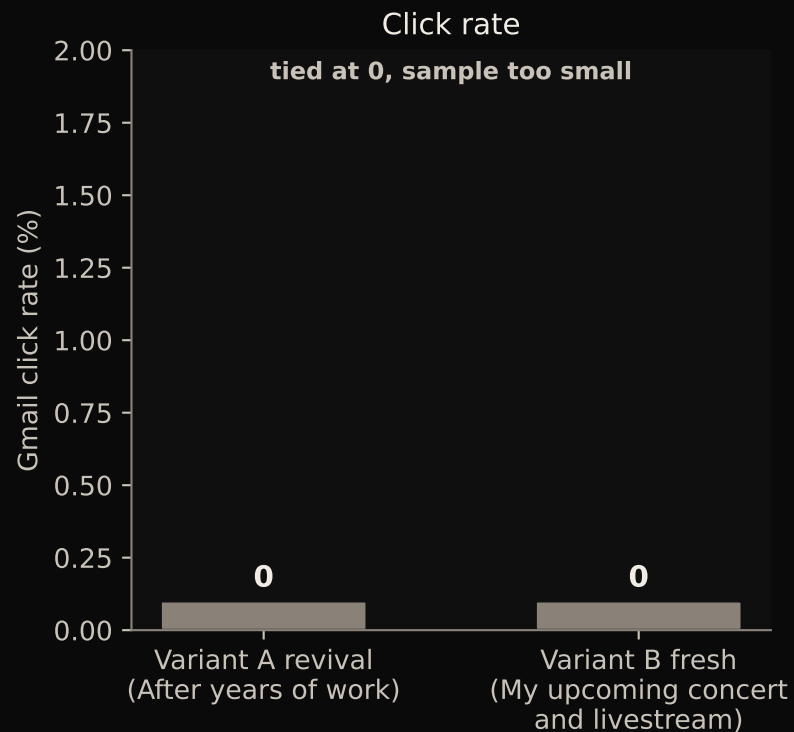
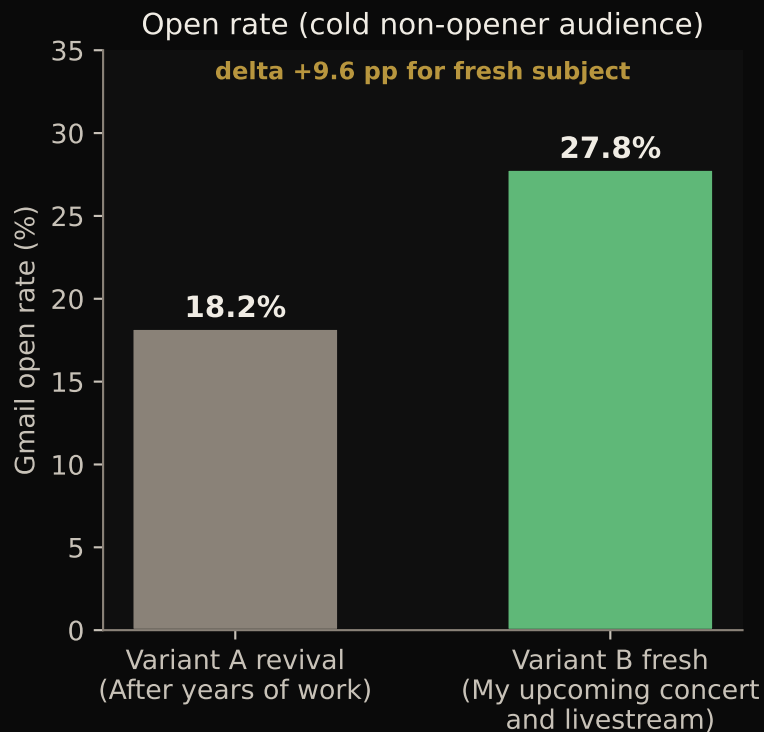
Winner: "My upcoming concert and livestream" (the "livestream" framing) was the most consistent.
"After years of work" hit 79% on initial small fresh-audience sends but bulk-flagged on the May 3 overnight.

A/B experiment 1, personalization on/off (Send 7, May 15)



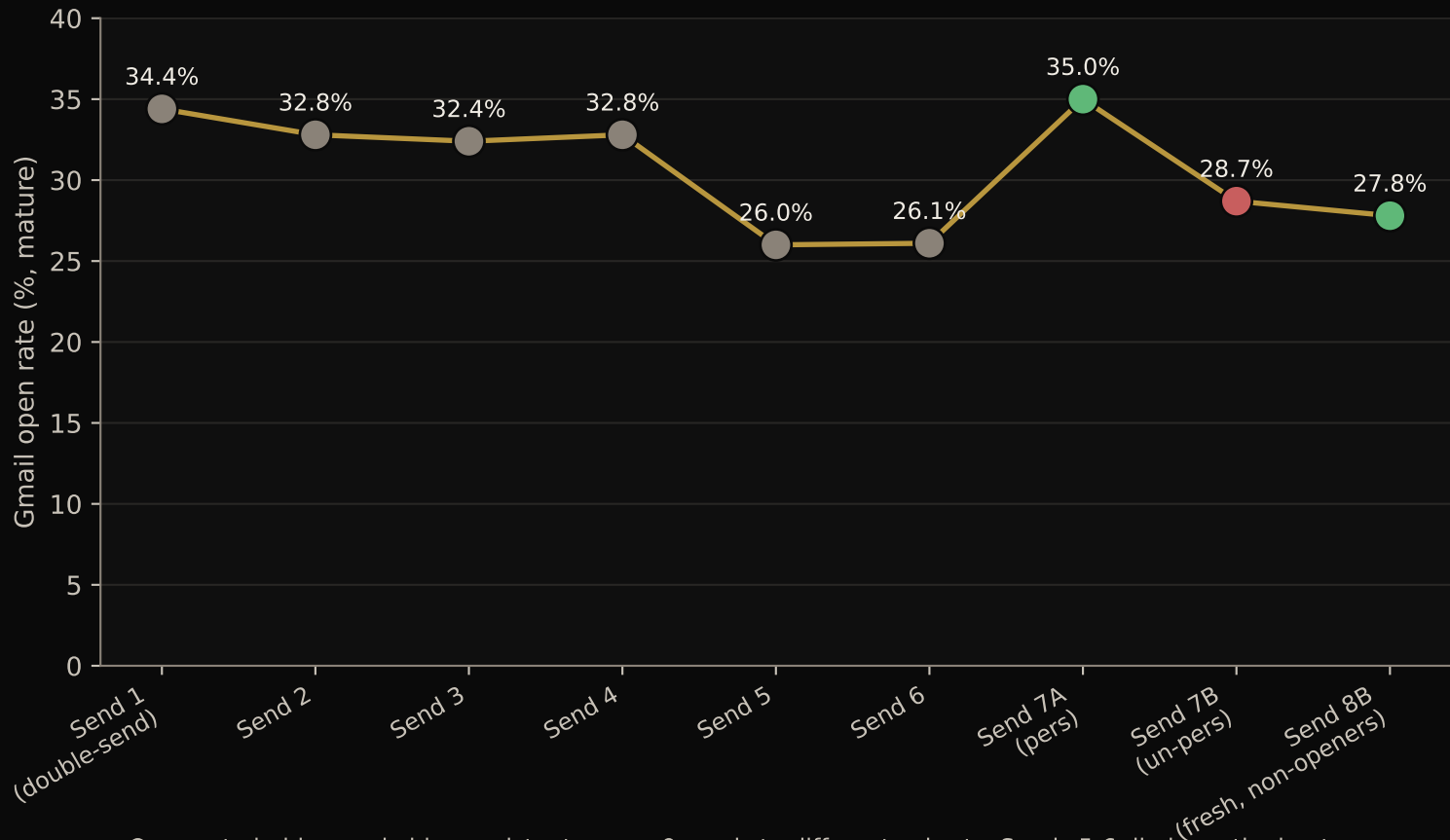
Finding: personalization adds ~6pp to inbox attention via the preview snippet "Hi [name], ..." but click intent once inside the email is unchanged. n=300 per arm, mature.

A/B experiment 2, Variant A revival vs Variant B fresh subject (Send 8, May 16, non-openers)



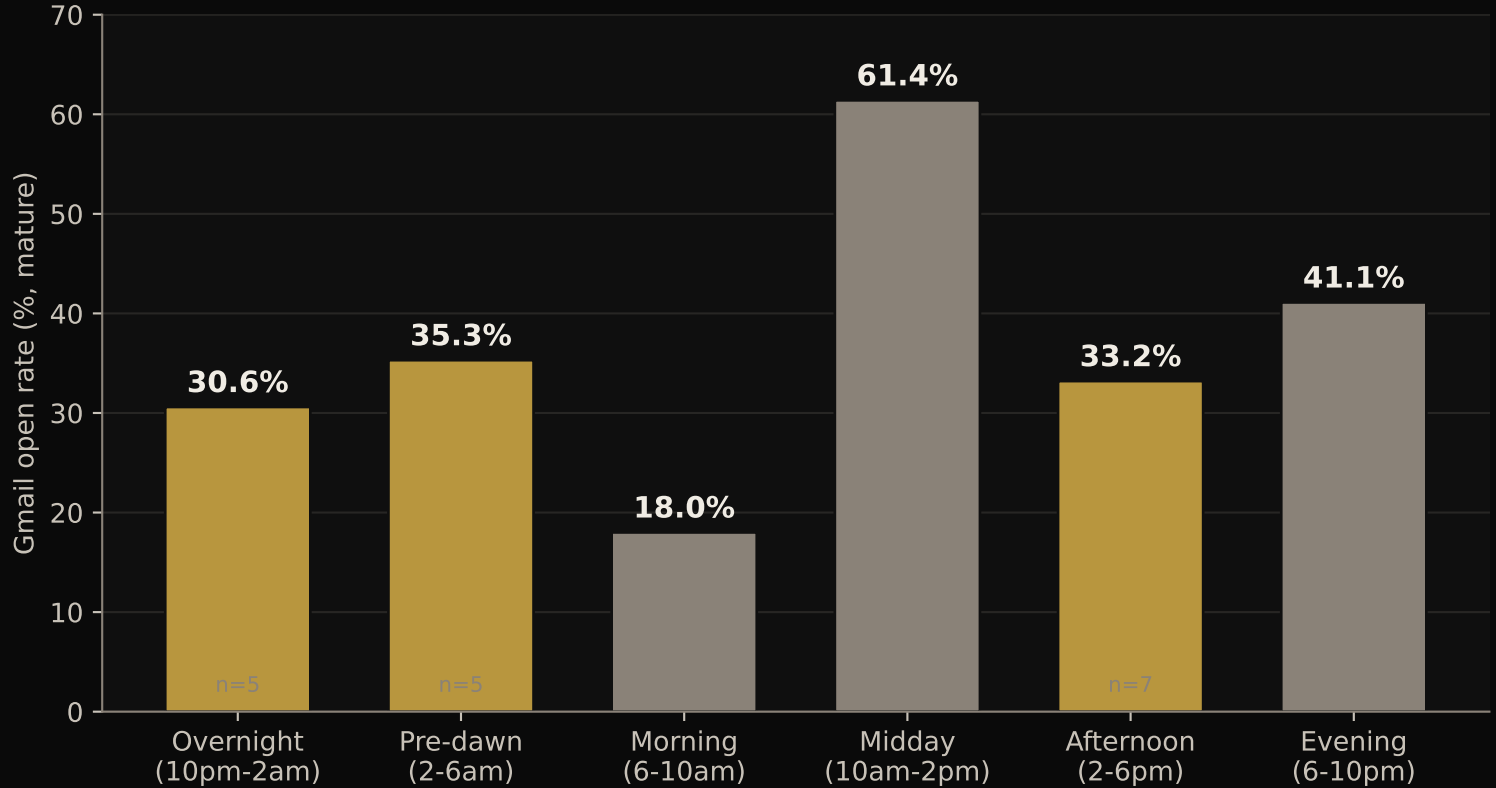
Finding: fresh subject hits harder than re-sending the email these recipients previously ignored.
Variant A re-send still recovered to 18.2%, confirming many never saw the original (May 3 bulk-flag).
n=214 (Arm A) + 209 (Arm B) delivered, mature.

Variant B "My upcoming concert and livestream" sends over time



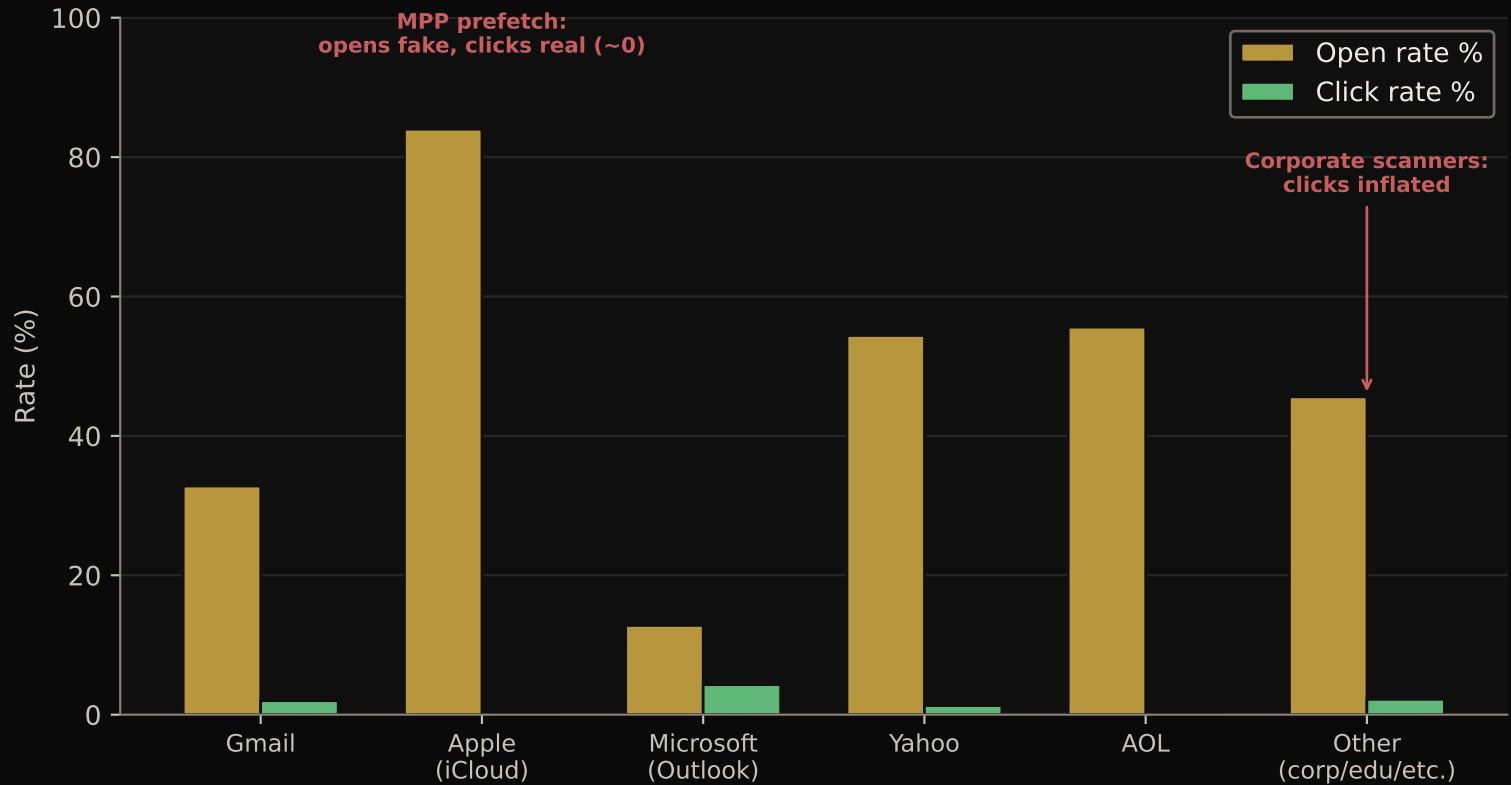
Open rate held remarkably consistent across 9 sends to different cohorts. Sends 5-6 dip is partly due to being measured at 13h/10h elapsed (not fully mature). The 'livestream' subject is robust across audiences.

Send timing by EDT hour bucket (mature, all clean sends)



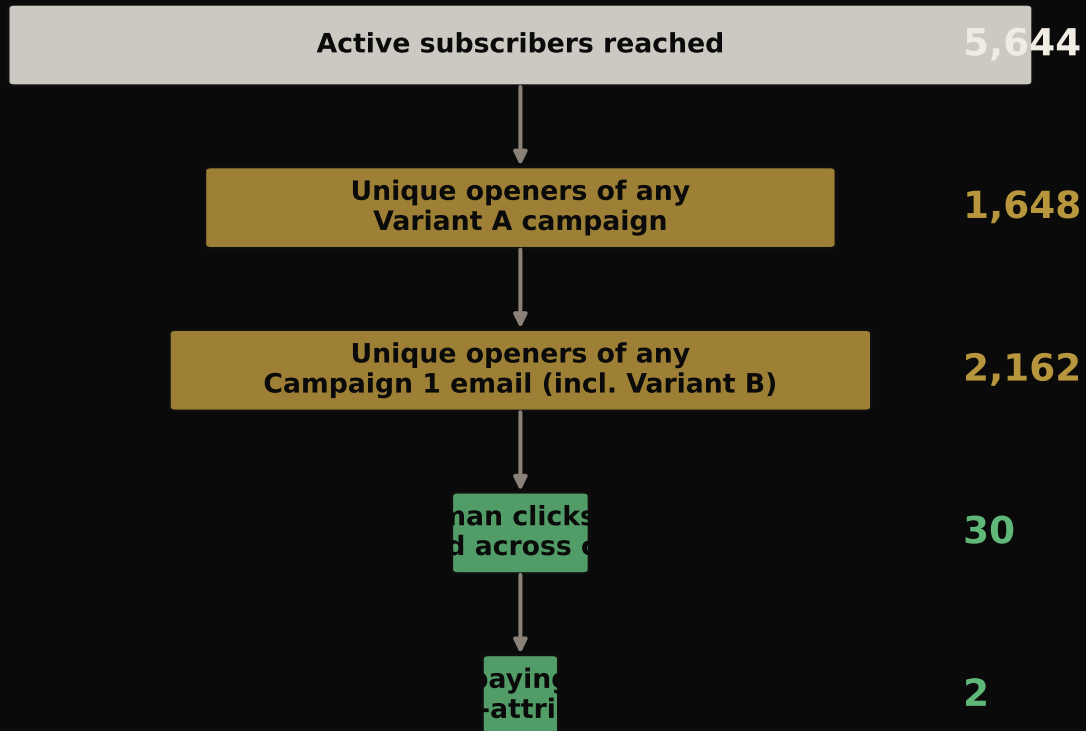
Bars in gold have larger samples ($n \geq 3$); pale bars ($n < 3$) are exploratory. Midday's 61.4% is heavily inflated by initial small fresh-audience sends. Within same-subject comparisons, afternoon and evening windows (2-10pm EDT) are the safe band, ~33-41%.

Open vs click rate by email provider (Send 2 mature, "livestream" subject)



Honest signal: Gmail open rate + click rate are reliable. Apple opens are MPP prefetch (delivery confirmation only). Other-domain (corporate/.edu) clicks are nearly all URL safety scanners. Real human cross-provider clicks were ~5-8 per 500.

Campaign 1 conversion funnel



+ 2 non-attributed paid orders (direct/social/word-of-mouth), bringing total concert tickets to 4

Key findings

Personalization adds attention but not action

Adding a 'Hi {first_name},' greeting at the top of the email body added 6.3 percentage points to Gmail open rate. The mechanism is the inbox preview snippet that shows the first body line; with the recipient's name in the preview, more open. Click rate once inside was unchanged at 0.7% (2 of 300 per arm).

Fresh subjects outperform re-sends on non-openers

When people didn't open Variant A the first time (in many cases because the May 3 redirect-mode bulk-flag landed them in spam), re-sending Variant A recovered 18.2% Gmail opens. Sending the fresh Variant B 'livestream' subject to the same audience hit 27.8%, a +9.6pp lift. Use new subjects for re-engagement.

'My upcoming concert and livestream' was the winning subject

Consistent 28-35% Gmail mature open rate across 9 sends. Most robust subject across audiences. 'After years of work' had a higher initial peak (79% on small fresh sends) but was hurt by the May 3 bulk-flag incident which collapsed slots 6-10.

Half of paid concert tickets came from email

2 of 4 confirmed paying customers were on the email list. Both clicked through 'After years of work' (the May 2 rotation send or the May 3 overnight). The other 2 buyers were not on the list, indicating social, direct, or word-of-mouth channels.

Honest-metric guidance

Lead with Gmail-only metrics

Gmail does not pre-fetch images. Gmail open rate is the closest thing to real human attention we can measure. Apple Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) auto-opens every email at delivery for every iCloud/Apple Mail user on iOS 15+, inflating Apple open rates to 60-95%. Yahoo and AOL prefetch similarly. Microsoft Defender is variable.

Apple clicks are real (when non-zero), Apple opens are not

MPP doesn't follow links. When an iCloud recipient does click, it's a real human signal. But MPP also rarely makes them open the email in their actual app, so click rates from Apple stay low for human reasons.

Other-domain (corporate/.edu) clicks are URL scanners

Mimecast, Proofpoint, Microsoft SafeLinks, Barracuda, and similar inbound URL-safety scanners pre-fetch every link in every email within seconds of delivery, often 2-3 fetches per recipient. On 2026-05-12 data, 100% of clicks from Other-domain recipients fired within 5 minutes of send. These are not human engagement.

When in doubt, look at Gmail click rate

Across Campaign 1, real human click rate was ~0.5-1% Gmail (2-5 clicks per 250 recipients, mature). Total click rate including all providers was 2-4x higher, but that delta was all scanner activity, not human engagement.

Notable incidents

2026-05-03 redirect-mode Gmail bulk-flagging

The overnight 10-batch Variant A send used `clickTrackingMode` `redirect`, which routes link clicks through a tracking domain before redirecting. Gmail's spam filter classified the inbound emails as suspicious starting at slot 5 (08:00Z), collapsing open rates from ~50% (slots 1-2) to under 5% (slots 6-10). About 2,000 recipients had their copy land in Promotions/Spam, never opened. Policy change: default to `clickTrackingMode` 'append' for all future sends.

2026-05-12 Gmail double-send (Send 1)

Send 1's Gmail child fired twice ~30 seconds apart due to an Inngest retry of the send-broadcast step. 250 recipients received the same email twice. Triggered a full post-incident response across the send pipeline:

- send-stream made idempotent (pre-loop `sent_history` check)
- per-recipient `sent_history` INSERT (no batching)
- Inngest concurrency lock account-scoped, limit 1
- DB UNIQUE constraint on `sent_history` (`campaign_id`, `subscriber_id`)
- send-safety-auditor subagent installed as a hard pre-send gate

No double-sends since. The auditor has caught real issues on subsequent runs that would have shipped without it.

What's next

Campaign 1 is closed

Pool 100% saturated. Every active subscriber has been touched.
Future Campaign 1 sends would require deliberately re-targeting previously-tagged recipients (the standard audience filter would return zero candidates).

Campaign 2 (No School Today) wave 1 is in flight

First production wave scheduled 2026-05-22T00:05Z / 00:10Z.
500 Gmail recipients split 250/250 testing designed HTML vs plain Gmail-style HTML, same subject and audience filter.
Audience drawn from done-belgium-followup-b tagged recipients excluding the 480 just sent for Campaign 1 final.

Concert is June 11, 2026

27 days from end-of-Campaign-1. Plenty of runway for further Campaign 2 waves and possibly a Campaign 1 re-target in the final week before the concert.

Sources of truth

- docs/CAMPAIGN-1-RESULTS.md, full prose write-up
- docs/SEND-AUDIT-LOG.md, per-send audit findings
- docs/SENDS-INDEX.md, scannable index of every send
- docs/INCIDENT-2026-05-12-gmail-double-send.md, incident